

In transition: Six-time champion Australia is emerging from the shadows of some illustrious names, including former captain Meg Lanning and Alyssa Healy, with talismanic left-arm spinner Sophie Molineux (below) now leading the side.



series-deciding loss at Taunton, but promoted Deepti Sharma above Richa Ghosh.

Richa, whose purple patch in 2023 gave the then newly appointed Muzumdar radical ideas about what all she could offer, now has just two scores above 40 since the turn of the year. Her ability to strike the ball remains intact, but she hasn't been able to stay long enough to produce an innings of some gravitas lately.

While Richa needs to find consistency, her place as India's first-choice keeper is fixed, making it a matter of belief. Instead of pigeonholing her into a flourish at the death, allow her to come in earlier and bat deep. If that fails, a much slower Deepti and the rest follow anyway.

A second question then becomes this: what was the point of bringing back Bharti? Meant to complement Richa's explosiveness down the order, the Vidarbha batter has yet to come

good and get a long enough run to really dig into the role. In the two T20I that India lost, she didn't make the XI either.

A hungry field

The T20 format might be the vehicle of propagation in the women's game, but gone are the days when teams are just happy to turn up and participate.

An expanded World Cup allows for teams like the Netherlands (a women's T20 World Cup debutant), Scotland, and Ireland to rub shoulders with the full members, many of whom are stagnating in the format. Pakistan, Bangladesh, and Sri Lanka have promising talent but rarely convert that into consistent victories, not enough to threaten the game's on-field oligarchy.

The outsiders — buoyed by a fresh European influx into the competitive pool — have, however, made some encouraging noises in the weeks leading up to the tournament.

The Netherlands and Scotland beat Bangladesh, while Ireland beat the West Indies and Pakistan in the past few weeks, giving their ambitions of registering wins at the T20 World Cup a massive shot in the arm.

That said, ambitions often fall at the doors of infrastructure and sides like South Africa, Australia, India, England, and New Zealand may not be so easy to topple. Defending champion New Zealand comes into the event after a 1-2 loss to England.

With this set to be the last hurrah for the golden trio of Suzie Bates, Sophie Devine, and Lea Tahuhu, an encore of 2024 may be beyond them. It's a transitional side still trying to define its voice in the international game, and captain and all-rounder Amelia Kerr shoulders a huge chunk of the load of carrying that megaphone.

Its trans-Tasman neighbour,